

US Shipping & Payment Gateway Options

Logistics partners and payment gateways for a custom-built ecommerce site | Volume: 100–1,000 orders/month | Prepared July 2026

1. Shipping & Logistics Partners — Ranked by Priority

Ranked for a custom-built site at 100–1,000 orders/month. Priority favors a developer-friendly API, low per-label cost, and easy integration into a custom checkout/order flow, over dashboard-only tools built for Shopify/Etsy sellers.

1	Shippo (API)	Multi-carrier shipping API — recommended core layer
Cost	Free tier: 30 labels/mo. Pro plans \$17–\$199/mo. Per-label (BYOCA): \$0.05.	
Per-order cost	≈ \$0.05 + carrier postage (carrier rates 40–67% off retail via pre-negotiated USPS/UPS discounts)	
Suitability (US, custom site)	Very good. 40+ carriers, native USPS/UPS/FedEx, handles USPS outages automatically, strong for 100–1,000 orders/mo.	
Pros	Lowest per-label fee; API on every plan incl. free tier; pre-negotiated carrier discounts; reliable webhooks for tracking.	
Cons	Free tier capped at 30 labels/mo (you'll need a paid tier fast); fewer total carriers than EasyPost (40+ vs 100+).	
Ease of implementation	Easy – REST API, well-documented, direct webhook support for order status sync.	

2	EasyPost (API)	Multi-carrier shipping API — best if you want max carrier coverage
Cost	Free Access Wallet: 3,000 labels/mo free, then \$0.08/label. BYOCA: \$20/mo + \$0.08/label.	
Per-order cost	≈ \$0.08/label + carrier postage (free up to 3,000 labels/mo on Wallet plan)	
Suitability (US, custom site)	Very good. 100+ carriers, 99.99% uptime SLA, built for custom storefronts and complex routing logic – a strong fit for a custom site.	
Pros	Generous 3,000 free labels/month; largest carrier network (100+); purpose-built for developers/custom apps; high reliability.	
Cons	Higher per-label fee than Shippo above the free tier; a new 3% fee applies on USPS PC Postage from June 2026; no native Shopify/Etsy dashboard.	
Ease of implementation	Easy – API-native by design, arguably the cleanest fit for a fully custom backend.	

3	USPS (direct or via API)	Primary carrier for light/domestic parcels
Cost	No subscription; pay per shipment at USPS/Commercial rates (via Shippo/EasyPost/Pirate Ship).	
Per-order cost	Lowest of all carriers for parcels under 5 lbs – no residential or fuel surcharges.	
Suitability (US, custom site)	Excellent as your default/cheapest carrier leg; delivers to every US address including PO boxes and rural routes.	
Pros	Lowest cost for light parcels; universal US address coverage; zero residential/fuel surcharges.	

Cons	Slower transit times; weaker native tracking/business tooling if used outside an aggregator; less ideal for heavy/high-value shipments.
Ease of implementation	Easy – access it through Shippo/EasyPost rather than USPS's own API directly.

4	UPS	Secondary carrier for heavier / B2B / reliable ground shipments
Cost	Ground Residential fee: \$6.50/package (Jan 2026) plus base rate; volume discounts available via aggregator.	
Per-order cost	Higher than USPS for light parcels; competitive for heavier/bulkier items with negotiated rates.	
Suitability (US, custom site)	Good complementary carrier once order sizes grow or you ship heavier/higher-value goods.	
Pros	Reliable, well-known brand customers trust; strong for heavier packages, B2B, insurance and customs handling.	
Cons	Residential surcharges make it cost-prohibitive for small, low-value parcels without volume discounts.	
Ease of implementation	Easy – enabled as one of the carrier options inside Shippo/EasyPost, no separate integration needed.	

5	FedEx	Secondary carrier for express / time-definite delivery
Cost	Comparable to UPS; base rate plus surcharges, better via negotiated/aggregator rates.	
Per-order cost	Similar tier to UPS; pricier than USPS for small/light shipments.	
Suitability (US, custom site)	Good if you need guaranteed delivery windows or ship nationally/internationally at meaningful volume.	
Pros	Strong for time-definite and international delivery; extensive network; good tracking granularity.	
Cons	Surcharge-heavy like UPS; not the cheapest option for small parcels; overlaps heavily with UPS so many stores only need one of the two.	
Ease of implementation	Easy – also available as a toggle-on carrier inside Shippo/EasyPost.	

6	Regional carrier (e.g., OnTrac, LSO, Veho)	Optional cost/speed booster once order geography is known
Cost	Typically lower per-package cost than national carriers within their footprint; no subscription, pay-per-shipment.	
Per-order cost	Often 10–30% cheaper than UPS/FedEx ground within their coverage zone.	
Suitability (US, custom site)	Add later, once you see where your 100–1,000 monthly orders concentrate geographically (e.g., Southeast, Texas, West Coast).	
Pros	Lower cost and often faster in-footprint delivery; more personalized service and support than national carriers.	
Cons	Regional/metro coverage only – cannot serve as your only carrier; requires a national carrier as backup for out-of-footprint orders.	
Ease of implementation	Moderate – add as a secondary carrier inside your aggregator once available in your ship-from region.	

Recommended stack: Shippo or EasyPost as the API layer, with USPS + UPS enabled as the two carriers (add FedEx or a regional carrier later based on volume/geography).

2. Payment Gateways — Best Suited for the USA

Ranked for a custom-built ecommerce site. Priority favors strong developer APIs, transparent US pricing, and no long-term contracts.

Rank	Gateway	Best For	US Cost	Pros	Cons
1	Stripe	Best overall fit for a custom-built site	2.9% + \$0.30 per online transaction. No monthly fee, no setup fee, no long-term contract.	Strongest developer API/docs of any gateway; scales cleanly; supports subscriptions, Apple Pay, Google Pay; fastest to integrate into a custom backend.	Standard-rate pricing can add up at very high volume (negotiable only at scale).
2	PayPal	Best as a secondary checkout option to boost conversion	≈2.9% + \$0.30 per US transaction. No setup or termination fees.	Most recognized brand in the US; often the highest checkout conversion rate; fast transfers; trusted by customers who don't want to enter card details.	Can have strict dispute/fund-hold policies; less developer-flexible than Stripe for custom flows.
3	Square	Best if you also plan to sell in person / have a physical storefront	Online: 2.9%–3.3% + \$0.30/transaction. Software plans \$0–\$149/mo depending on tier.	Unifies online and in-person payments in one system; good POS hardware ecosystem; no long-term contract.	Less specialized for complex online-only or subscription billing than Stripe; monthly software fee on higher tiers.
4	Authorize.Net	Best once you're at higher volume and already have a merchant account	All-in-One: \$25/mo + 2.9% + \$0.30/transaction. Gateway-only (with your own merchant account): \$25/mo + \$0.10/transaction + \$0.10 batch fee.	Long-established, broad ecommerce platform compatibility; flexible to connect with multiple merchant account providers.	Monthly fee makes it less attractive for low-volume/early-stage stores; dashboard/UI often described as dated and less intuitive.
5	Adyen	Best only once you scale to enterprise-level volume (\$250K+/month)	One-time setup: €500–€5,000+. Monthly platform fee: €120–€300. Per-transaction: interchange + ~0.6% Adyen fee (charged per authorization attempt, including failed ones).	Enterprise-grade fraud tools; local payment processing improves approval rates internationally; negotiable rates at high volume.	Setup and monthly platform fees make it unsuitable for startups/low-volume stores; charges per authorization attempt, not just successful ones.

Recommendation: use **Stripe** as your primary gateway for the cleanest custom-site integration, with **PayPal** offered as a secondary option at checkout to capture customers who prefer it. Revisit Authorize.Net or Adyen only once volume/enterprise needs justify their fees.

Note: Pricing is sourced from public vendor and industry pricing pages as of July 2026 and is subject to change; confirm current rates directly with each provider before signing up. This document is for planning purposes and is not financial or legal advice.